

A Walk to the Jetty



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF JAMAICA KINCAID

Born Elaine Potter Richardson, Jamaica Kincaid grew up in Antigua with her mother, stepfather, and three younger brothers. Kincaid garnered much success in the British education system that existed in Antigua during her youth. At 17, Kincaid left home to work as an au pair in Scarsdale, New York after her stepfather became ill and her mother insisted that she financially contribute to their family. This forced move, in addition to Kincaid's resentment at her mother for prioritizing her sons over her daughter, ultimately culminated in Kincaid's estrangement from her family. In 1973, Kincaid changed her name upon her first magazine publication in hopes of redefining herself. She later married composer and professor Allen Shawn, though they divorced in 2002. Kincaid now lives in Vermont and teaches African and African American Studies at Harvard University.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Christopher Columbus surveyed the island of Antigua in 1493, naming it "Santa Maria de la Antigua" after the Spanish church of the same name. In 1632, the British formally colonized Antigua and took control of the nearby smaller island of Barbuda by 1678. With British colonial rule came the rise of slavery in the islands, as the British enslaved millions of native Africans to provide free labor for their lucrative sugar plantations. In 1834, the British passed the Slave Abolition Act, which granted freedom to approximately 750,000 enslaved people in the West Indies. Despite the legal abolition of slavery, however, the newly freed populations found themselves remaining economically dependent on white plantation owners and still subjected to the same race- and class-based hierarchies that existed alongside slavery. Finally, in 1981, Antigua and Barbuda achieved independence from the United Kingdom and became recognized as one country.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Following *Annie John*, Kincaid's first novel (of which this story is an excerpt), Kincaid continued to write about young girls leaving their homes in the Caribbean. She also built on similar themes of migration, independence, and gender in her second novel, *Lucy*. Published in 1990, *Lucy* features a young female protagonist who must learn to adjust to life in America after leaving her Caribbean island, much like Annie John. *My Brother*, a work of nonfiction that Kincaid published in 1997, gives insight to Kincaid's youth in Antigua with her family, which may help contextualize some autobiographically inspired moments

in *Annie John*, such as Annie's father's illness. Looking to other authors from the West Indies, British-Dominican author Jean Rhys's famous 1966 novel *Wide Sargasso Sea* similarly investigates themes of race, gender, and assimilation. The daughter of a father who immigrated from Barbados, Paule Marshall was another writer who, in her 1959 novel *Brown Girl, Brownstones*, portrayed the experiences of Barbadian immigrants in New York.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** A Walk to the Jetty
- **When Written:** 1982–1983
- **Where Written:** New York City
- **When Published:** 1985
- **Literary Period:** Postcolonialism
- **Genre:** Short Story
- **Setting:** Antigua
- **Climax:** Upon arriving at the jetty, Annie becomes deathly afraid that she will fall into the water and realizes she is about to leave behind her life as she knows it.
- **Antagonist:** The short story does not have a traditional antagonist, but Annie struggles against the implications of gender roles, a strained relationship with her mother, and her fear of leaving home.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Staffer Stories. The chapters that would become the novel *Annie John* were first published as individual stories in *The New Yorker*, where Kincaid worked as a staff writer from 1976 to 1996.

Implications of Autobiography. Although readers often describe Kincaid's work as autobiographical, Kincaid asserts that many writers find inspiration in their personal experiences and that her work should not be pigeon-holed. To this end, Kincaid encourages readers to resist literal interpretations when encountering autobiographically-inspired material in her work.



PLOT SUMMARY

"A Walk to the Jetty" begins in Annie John's bedroom on the morning of her final day in Antigua. Today, Annie will board a ship bound for Barbados, then another ship enroute to England. Annie thinks to herself that although she does not

want to live in England or study to become a nurse there, she never wants to lie in her childhood bed again. In fact, she thinks, she would gladly accept any opportunity to leave home. Annie finds familiarity in the fact that her mother, Mrs. Annie John, and her father, Alexander, made every piece of furniture and clothing in her bedroom and their home, but Annie feels that she no longer loves her parents as she once did. She has also vowed to never marry—especially not an old man like her father.

At the sound of a church bell signaling that it is seven o'clock, Annie gets out of bed. Her mother greets her brightly, and as Annie prepares for the day, she realizes that her mother sent her underclothes and jewelry to a woman who enchanted the items to keep her safe from harm. Annie shares breakfast with her parents, and she finds their excitement odd and ironic—as though they are celebrating the fact that she's leaving them. Annie brushes off her mother's comment that she may soon get married.

At 10 o'clock, Annie and her parents begin their walk to the jetty. They pass important locations from Annie's youth, including a seamstress's home where she apprenticed, the road Annie used to take to school, the church her family attends, old friends' homes, and the library that Annie and her mother often visited.

Annie begins to feel disconnected from her body and surroundings. As she approaches the jetty, she succumbs to her old fear of falling into the sea, where the eels live. At this point, Annie realizes the gravity of her situation: she is leaving behind everyone and everything she knows. Numb, she initially cannot decide how to react but pushes through waves of fear, uncertainty, and nostalgia. Annie assures herself that she is no longer a child and that she must go through with the decision she made.

Annie and her father share a short goodbye, and Alexander seems unable to tell his daughter what is on his mind. Mrs. Annie begins to cry as she hugs her daughter, which triggers Annie's tears, too. Mrs. Annie reminds her daughter that Antigua will always be her home, just as she will always be her mother. Annie's parents then deboard the ship, and Annie searches for them from the deck. Finding only her mother in the crowd, Annie waves a red handkerchief until the ship has traveled so far into the sea that her mother is a mere speck on land. In her cabin, Annie lies down and listens to the waves lapping against the ship.

allow her to live on her own terms. Emotionally distant from her parents and disinterested in a traditional marriage, Annie also feels particularly constricted by her relationship with her mother, Mrs. Annie John, whom she finds overbearing and hypocritical. While walking to the jetty, however, Annie's cynicism gives way to nostalgia as she reflects on all the memories she has made—particularly with her mother—while growing up in Antigua, and she realizes for the first time that her life is about to change forever. By the end of the story, Annie no longer seems to view her hometown and family in a black-and-white manner, and she acknowledges the fondness she holds for the familiarity of her old life. As she bids her parents farewell, she cries alongside her mother, and they share a final tender moment when Annie spots her mother in the crowd and waves until her ship has traveled too far.

Mrs. Annie John – Annie's mother, Mrs. Annie John, dedicates much of her time to caring for her family and looking after her sick husband, Alexander, in his old age. Although Annie's rebelliousness prevents her from fully appreciating her mother's efforts, Mrs. Annie is meticulous in helping her daughter prepare for her move to England. From sending her daughter's belongings to an obeah woman for protective enchantments to ironing Annie's moving-day clothes and ensuring she exudes positivity and excitement, Mrs. Annie does her best to support her daughter's independence—even if that means they must live apart. In fact, as Annie reminisces on her childhood, she remembers her mother allowing her, at 5-years-old, to visit the local chemist's shop alone and make a purchase. At the end of the story, though, Mrs. Annie's façade falls, and she cries while saying goodbye to her daughter, revealing that her outward image of maternal strength is also tempered by her love and emotion.

Alexander John – Alexander is Annie's father. Thirty-five years older than his wife, Mrs. Annie John, Alexander also has two children from a previous relationship, and they are four and six years older than his current wife. Although Alexander built his family's home and crafted much of the furniture in it, he has fallen ill in his old age and relies on his wife to care for him while also refusing to take his prescribed medications. Alexander is relatively distant from his daughter Annie, which leads to her feeling disconnected from him. Nonetheless, he tries to send Annie off to England with a festive farewell. During Alexander's final goodbye to Annie, he wishes her well, then hesitates as though he has something else to say. Alexander ultimately does not share what is on his mind, remaining a somewhat stereotypical image of a masculine father.

Gwen – Although they have grown apart, Gwen is Annie's old friend and the only person outside of her immediate family to whom she feels obligated to say goodbye. Annie now finds Gwen silly and embarrassing due to Gwen's giggly demeanor, and when Gwen reveals that she will soon marry, Annie feels that the two of them have fully grown apart. Girlish and



CHARACTERS

Annie John – Annie, the protagonist of "A Walk to the Jetty," is a 17-year-old Antiguan girl preparing to move to England to study to become a nurse. Largely resistant to societal and familial expectations, Annie believes that leaving home will

uncritical of traditional marriage, Gwen seems to embody the very lifestyle that Annie detests. Although Annie is polite to her old friend, she is also able to say goodbye to Gwen with no emotional repercussions, further emphasizing her lack of interest in a traditional lifestyle.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



GENDER AND AUTONOMY

"A Walk to the Jetty" explores the idea that it's often more complicated than it might initially seem for women to attain true autonomy in a patriarchal

society. For instance, 17-year-old Annie seems on the cusp of achieving a sense of autonomy that will transcend the stifling expectations foisted on women in her Antiguan society. She is, after all, about to leave Antigua behind and, in doing so, perhaps avoid leading a life similar to her mother's—that is, a life dedicated to caring for a man. Annie opposes her mother's lifestyle so indignantly that she finds she can't even stand the sounds of her mother getting ready in the morning, which is an indication of just how eager she is to extract herself from her mother's world. And because Annie does not know any Antiguan women living outside the confines of a traditional marriage, she ultimately feels isolated and believes she must leave her island in search of the freedom she desires.

However, the fact remains that Annie doesn't actually *want* to live in England or become a nurse—she simply wants to escape the stifling expectations to which her family and fellow Antiguan community members cling. The problem, though, is that it's not so certain that leaving home will enable her to escape such expectations. During their final breakfast together, Annie's mother says she won't be surprised if Annie soon writes home with plans for marriage, thus illustrating that leaving home will do basically nothing to change the fact that Annie is expected to prioritize and aspire toward marriage. In this way, it becomes clear that Annie will face the same expectations to which she would be subjected if she were to stay in Antigua. By hinting that Annie's relocation probably won't lead to a genuine sense of autonomy or freedom, the story highlights the extreme difficulty of escaping or transcending the expectations of a patriarchal society.



COMING OF AGE

"A Walk to the Jetty" demonstrates how growing up often requires young people to renegotiate their

beliefs and identities. Straddling the line between youth and adulthood, Annie looks upon her current life with a critical eye as she reflects on the aspects of her childhood that she is impatient to leave behind. For one, Annie views her parents in a particularly cynical manner. While sharing her final breakfast with them, Annie focuses on how her father's false teeth make a "clop-clop sound like a horse on a walk" and her mother's mouth "[goes] up and down like a donkey's," suggesting that she doesn't quite view her parents as fellow humans—an idea that underscores just how disconnected she feels from them. At the same time, after Annie walks through her town on the way to the jetty, she reminisces on memories she made as a young girl at her old church, doctor's office, library, and more, and she finds herself overcome with emotions at the idea of leaving her life and family behind. This deep and unexpected nostalgia pushes Annie to confront the truth that she does, in fact, hold fondness for her life in Antigua despite her determination to leave it behind. By the end of the story, Annie and her mother share a tender parting moment, revealing to the reader that Annie's feelings toward her home are not so black-and-white after all and that she has grown into a young woman who can view the world in a more nuanced manner. Ultimately, by underscoring Annie's budding acceptance of her family and home, Kincaid emphasizes the idea that coming of age is a complex process that involves more than simply developing one's identity in opposition to others—and this ongoing process of maturation can even involve embracing what one once shunned or resisted.



COLONIALISM AND CULTURE

While Antiguan characters in "A Walk to the Jetty" do not criticize the British presence in their society, Kincaid subtly portrays the dissonance of native and colonial culture butting against one another. In the story, British presence and the related influence of Christianity saturate Antigua: an Anglican church bell signals the time to Annie; Annie attends Sunday school and choir practice; and on her way to the jetty, she reminisces on the porcelain dog she discovered in a store that sells grooming aids imported from England. Importantly, Annie's parents have also portrayed England as a place of opportunity for her to study nursing and make a living for herself. While British influence exists throughout Antigua, however, Kincaid also demonstrates that British culture has not eclipsed Antiguan culture. Rather, Antiguan culture remains alive in the face of British control. For example, although Annie's mother sends Annie away with a copy of the Bible, she is also sure to send all of Annie's jewelry and underclothing to an obeah woman to protect Annie from evil spirits and misfortune. In showing the coexistence in Antiguan culture of Christian and spiritual folk rituals, Kincaid underscores the omnipresence of colonialism as well as the survival of native Antiguan culture. This portrayal of the

coexistence of British colonialism and Antiguan culture, then, invites the reader to consider the resilience of Antiguan people in the face of colonialism.



MOTHER-DAUGHTER RELATIONSHIPS

Although Annie often finds her mother's expressions of care somewhat hypocritical, memories of her mother are what most

prominently come to mind as she makes her final walk through town on the way to the jetty. Annie does not understand how her mother can support her move to England when she once claimed that she could not live apart from her daughter, but as Annie recounts her most noteworthy childhood memories, it becomes clear—at least to the reader—that Annie's mother has been attempting to support Annie's independence since she has been old enough to visit the store alone. As Annie dresses herself for her big day, she does not seem to take much note of her mother's efforts in helping her prepare, from sending her jewelry and underclothes to an obeah woman to ironing her clothing. Despite Annie's resistance to her mother, Kincaid concludes the story with Annie searching for her mother in the crowd for one final goodbye, which suggests that their relationship may grow closer and more honest in the upcoming era of their lives. By ending the story on Annie's growing receptiveness to her mother's care, Kincaid indicates that, while often fraught with emotional turmoil, the mother-daughter relationship can be a deep bond capable of outlasting and overcoming considerable interpersonal tension.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



WATER

Water in "A Walk to the Jetty" symbolizes how movement and migration offer transformative opportunities in the face of confinement or restriction. As Annie arrives at the jetty, she is physically stepping away her old life in Antigua and toward a new life in England, casting away the familial and societal expectations by which she feels confined. In this moment of transition, Annie becomes fearful and sees the sea below her as an ominous, dark green body of water where eels lurk. Here, the state of the water represents the potential danger and despair that Annie may experience during and after her journey. The sea quickly changes, however, to a more typical blue color once Annie boards the ship, hinting that change often becomes less daunting once a person embraces it.

While Annie's arrival at the jetty brings about her most sustained observation of water in the short story, Annie also

mentions others who have traveled across the sea. For example, a girl with whom Annie briefly plays in her youth disappears from Annie's life after moving across the sea. Although Annie does not know what becomes of her, a journey across the water allows the girl a means to leave the confinement of an island, and there is a sense of freedom, too, in the way that she disappears into obscurity, at least as far as Annie is concerned.

Annie's father also relies on water to free him from the restrictive nature of his illness as he ritually drinks water boiled with herbs and bark—and, notably, chooses this route instead of traditional medicine. In this case, movement or migration is figurative rather than physical. As Annie's father hopes to heal and distance himself from his sickness, the herb-infused water he drinks represents a chance for him to undergo a transformation that would free him from the illness that keeps him reliant on his wife's care and unable to live as he once did.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Cambridge University Press edition of *Stories of Ourselves: Volume 2* published in 2018.

A Walk to the Jetty Quotes

💬 "My name is Annie John." These were the first words that came into my mind as I woke up on the morning of the last day I spent in Antigua, and they stayed there, lined up one behind the other, marching up and down, for I don't know how long...My name was the last thing I saw the night before, just as I was falling asleep; it was written in big, black letters all over my trunk, sometimes followed by my address in Antigua, sometimes followed by my address as it would be in England.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 338

Explanation and Analysis

This passage opens the story and introduces the reader to Annie, who is about to leave her home in Antigua for the very first time. Considering the geographical distance between Antigua—an island in the Caribbean—and England, Annie's new life will certainly require adjustment, and her impulse to remind herself of her own name seems to represent an effort to ground herself in her identity on the cusp of significant life changes.

In addition to introducing the reader to Annie, the statement “My name is Annie John” also mimics how Annie will introduce herself to new people upon arriving in England. In this sense, Annie subconsciously prepares herself for the new life and relationships that lie ahead. Although she does not tell the reader outright that she is afraid or apprehensive, Annie’s attempts to calm and prepare herself point to more complex emotions surrounding her experience of entering young adulthood.

Annie’s meditation on the statement “My name is Annie John” also demonstrates that she is reflecting on who she is and what it means to be Annie John. At 17 years old, Annie is on the verge of adulthood and is beginning to make important decisions for herself. In visualizing her name alongside her current and future addresses, Annie reveals that she derives some of her sense of identity from her relationship to significant places—but still finds herself in the transitional period between her old home and new life.

☛ I never wanted to lie in my bed again and hear Mr. Ephraim driving his sheep to pasture—a signal to my mother that she should get up to prepare my father’s and my bath and breakfast. I never wanted to lie in my bed and hear her get dressed, washing her face, brushing her teeth, and gargling. I especially never wanted to lie in my bed and hear my mother gargling again.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 338

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie lies in her bed, recounting—with distaste—the sounds she often hears in the morning. Annie’s repetition of “I never wanted to lie in my bed” emphasizes just how deeply she despises these sounds and dislikes her home life and how ready she is to leave it all behind.

It’s also important to note that the sounds in this passage all either come from Annie’s mother or remind Annie of her. While Annie asserts her dislike of the sounds, she does not describe her feelings toward her mother in the same direct manner. Annie’s desire to never again hear her mother getting ready in the morning, however, does imply a sense of disconnect, frustration, and even anger—Annie is

disproportionately annoyed by the relatively quiet sounds of her mother getting dressed and gargling, and that annoyance seems to stand in for her deeper, unexpressed negative feelings toward her mother. This emotional response situates Annie in the often-turbulent period between childhood and adulthood, when many people feel torn between childhood affections and loyalties and the desire to assert oneself as an adult.

☛ My mother’s name is Annie also. My father’s name is Alexander, and he is thirty-five years older than my mother. Two of his children are four and six years older than she is. Looking at how sickly he has become and looking at the way my mother now has to run up and down for him, gathering the herbs and barks that he boils in water, which he drinks instead of the medicine the doctor has ordered for him, I plan not only to never marry an old man but certainly never to marry at all.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 339

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie gives context to her parents’ relationship and emphasizes her resistance to following in her mother’s footsteps and becoming a traditional wife. Here, it is noteworthy that Annie simply states facts about her mother and father and describes actions that she has observed from them. Even so, Annie’s determination to never marry communicates that she is critical of her parents and their relationship—her sick father’s aversion to medicine frustrates her, and “the way [her] mother now has to run up and down” to take care of her father is not a role that Annie sees herself fulfilling for a husband in the future.

Together, Alexander’s ability to refuse medication and Mrs. Annie being subjected to his whims establishes the image of a traditionally patriarchal marriage. As the wife, Mrs. Annie shoulders the gendered expectation of being caring and nurturing while Alexander is free to defy his doctor’s orders and preserve a guise of masculinity in so doing. This traditional image of a marriage is the main example Annie has had to look to, and she despises it.

It is also possible that the significant age gap between Mrs. Annie and Alexander may worsen this already unequal power dynamic. With Alexander's children from his previous relationship being close in age to Mrs. Annie (in fact, they're older than her), Alexander's age may contribute to his failure to view Mrs. Annie as his equal. Since Mrs. Annie is Annie's main example of womanhood and her parents' dynamic is her main example of marriage, Annie feels not only resistant to her mother's lifestyle but trapped by the expectations it creates for her own life.

☞ For most of my life, when the three of us went anywhere together I stood between the two of them or sat between the two of them. But then I got too big, and there I was, shoulder to shoulder with them more or less, and it became not very comfortable to walk down the street together. And so now there they are together and here I am apart. I don't see them now the way I used to, and I don't love them now the way I used to.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 339

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie reflects on the image of her younger self fitting between her parents and how, at 17 years old, she feels she has physically and emotionally grown apart from them. Annie explains that she eventually “got too big,” which made it “not very comfortable to walk down the street together.” Since it would be simple for Annie's parents to step aside to make room for her between them and continue walking down the street together, the “discomfort” that Annie describes cannot be attributed solely to the logistical difficulty of walking between her parents in a physically larger body.

Instead, Annie's discomfort stems from feeling out of place in public while walking alongside her parents. After growing taller and more physically mature, Annie's identity as a teenage girl on the verge of womanhood becomes more apparent to those around her, and with that identity comes a more defined gender role and stricter expectations for what a woman should and should not do.

When Annie is a young girl, for example, the image of her and her parents—a nuclear family—conforms to Antigua

society's traditional expectations of marriage and child-rearing. As Annie approaches womanhood, however, she is no longer free to simply be her parents' child, and society places new gendered expectations upon her, such as becoming a wife and mother herself eventually. These changing expectations account for Annie's feeling of being “apart” from her parents despite having once fit so comfortably between them.

☞ Everything I would do that morning until I got on the ship that would take me to England I would be doing for the last time, for I had made up my mind that, come what may, the road for me now went only in one direction: away from my home, away from my mother, away from my father, away from the everlasting blue sky, away from the everlasting hot sun, away from people who said to me, “This happened during the time your mother was carrying you.”

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 339-340

Explanation and Analysis

This passage reveals Annie's perspective that her move to England is permanent and that she only envisions herself as moving further away from her family and Antigua. Annie repeats “away from” as she lists everything and everyone she will leave behind, emphasizing her certainty in this moment—she truly believes that “the road for [her] now [goes] only in one direction” (in other words, that she'll never willingly turn back to her old home and way of life) and that she will only find freedom and happiness outside of Antigua. So far, Annie has defined herself in opposition to her parents, their home, and all of that society whose opinion of her is informed by their knowledge of her through her mother. Importantly, she's confident in this oppositional way of understanding herself.

At the same time, it's important to note that in addition to “home,” “mother,” and “father,” Annie also lists the “everlasting blue sky” and “everlasting hot sun.” Her repetition of “everlasting” arguably complicates her certainty about leaving her old life behind. After all, it's impossible to escape the sky or sun even after traveling across the globe—and this suggests that she'll carry around her relationships to Antigua and her parents even if she is no longer physically with them.

☛ There was only one person I felt I should say goodbye to, and that was my former friend Gwen. We had long ago drifted apart, and when I saw her now my heart nearly split in two with embarrassment at the feelings I used to have for her and the things I shared with her. She had now degenerated into complete silliness...[S]he told me that she was more or less engaged to a boy she had known while growing up early on in Nevis...But to me it was as if she had shown me a high point from which she was going to jump and hoped to land in one piece on her feet.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Gwen

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 341

Explanation and Analysis

Prior to this passage, Annie goes through the formalities of saying goodbye to her mother's friends, other women in their community. Here, Annie expresses that the one young woman she does feel some semblance of connection to is her old friend Gwen. Close in age to Annie, Gwen and her presence in the story offer Annie another chance to imagine what life as a woman in Antiguan society could look like for her. While Gwen seems youthful and happy, though, Annie views her as having "degenerated into complete silliness," and this strongly negative language emphasizes that womanhood—at least as Gwen and other Antiguan women engage in it—is unredeemable to her.

In comparing her image of Gwen's future marriage to the idea of Gwen jumping from "a high point" and "[hoping] to land in one piece," Annie makes clear that she believes marriage is a losing prospect for women. This extreme comparison also implies that Annie believes that Gwen—and other women—have absolutely no chance at happiness in marriage and may even experience serious harm by choosing a traditional married life.

☛ I had just had a bath, and after it, instead of powdering me with my baby-smelling talcum powder, my mother had, as a special favor, let me use her own talcum powder, which smelled quite perfumy and came in a can...How it pleased me to walk out the door and bend my head down to sniff at myself and see that I smelled just like my mother.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 342

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie thinks back to her earlier youth, when her feelings toward her mother were more positive and loving. This memory provides important context for the current state of Annie's relationship with her mother: Annie wasn't always agitated by the sounds of her mother getting ready in the morning. In fact, feeling connected and similar to her mother through the scent of her special talcum powder was a "special favor" Annie used to ask for.

It's important to underscore that Annie's mother "let" Annie use her talcum powder—meaning that Annie powdering herself with her mother's product is something that Annie actively wanted and not something that her mother imposed upon her. Here, the talcum powder allows a younger Annie to connect with her mother and engage in a traditional sort of femininity (through a beauty product). Unlike present-day Annie, younger Annie delighted in the feeling of this feminine, mother-daughter connection, which suggests that, even now, Annie and her mother's relationship runs deeper than Annie quite realizes or lets on.

☛ My heart now beat fast, and no matter how hard I tried, I couldn't keep my mouth from falling open and my nostrils spreading to the ends of my face. My old fear of slipping between the boards of the jetty and falling into the dark-green water where the dark-green eels lived came over me.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 344

Explanation and Analysis

Annie arrives at the jetty with her parents in this passage and, for the first time in the story, feels terrified. Annie's description of her bodily experience here is an interesting reminder that she tells this story from her point of view and can, at times, be an unreliable narrator—at least in the sense that strong emotions impact how she experiences and shares her version of the story. For example, the slight exaggeration of Annie's mouth "falling open" and "nostrils spreading to the ends of [her] face" communicates how

afraid and shocked Annie feels in this moment, but these phrases may not accurately represent how other characters view her. Nonetheless, Annie's strong bodily experience suggests that her perspective on her situation may be about to change, too.

In this passage, the water takes on an almost antagonistic role as Annie associates it with her old fear of falling and drowning among eels. The ominous water represents Annie's newly changed feelings about leaving Antigua—while Annie previously focused on how moving away from home will free her from everything she despises about home, the danger of falling into the water and drowning speaks to the difficulties and even potential perils of moving away that she has not yet fully reflected on.

☛ My mother and my father—I was leaving them forever. My home on an island—I was leaving it forever. What to make of everything? I felt a familiar hollow space inside. I felt I was being held down against my will. I felt I was burning up from head to toe. I felt that someone was tearing me up into little pieces and soon I would be able to see all the little pieces as they floated out into nothing in the deep blue sea.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 344

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie has arrived at the jetty and must now confront the complex reality of leaving Antigua and her family behind. In the first half of this passage, Annie's language grows more fragmented, and she begins the first two sentences by emphasizing the three main things she is leaving behind: her mother, father, and "home on an island." Her sentences here are also short in comparison to her usual longer ones (like the final sentence of this passage). This new way of expressing herself reflects the awakening that Annie experiences and how she is grappling with it: Annie is now beginning to understand that chasing opportunity in a new place means that she will no longer have the familiarity of home and family around her.

While Annie has been critical of her home and family, her coming of age involves her recognizing the fondness she

does hold toward them, bubbling beneath the surface. In other words, Annie previously viewed herself as someone who could not fit in Antigua and alongside her parents—so much so that her understanding of herself hinged on how she differed from those around her. Here, though, Annie's fragmented language and her vivid descriptions of how she feels in her body allow the reader to experience Annie's renegotiation of her beliefs alongside her. It becomes clear that Annie is reconsidering the thoughts and beliefs she had been so confident in just a short time before.

The symbol of water appears in this passage, too, following Annie's descriptions of hollowness, feeling constrained, burning, and being torn up. These sensations are powerful and communicate the potent sadness that Annie now feels. Perhaps most interesting is Annie's feeling of being torn into pieces and cast into the sea. Although there is a pain from being torn like paper, this image also implies that when the figurative "little pieces" of Annie are in the water, she can truly look at all parts of herself and reflect more honestly on her identity and desires. The sea here facilitates distance and clarity, allowing a more mature Annie to realize that she does, in fact, love her home.

☛ From the deck, I could not see my father, but I could see my mother facing the ship, her eyes searching to pick me out. I removed from my bag a red cotton handkerchief that she had earlier given me for this purpose, and I waved it wildly in the air. Recognizing me immediately, she waved back just as wildly, and we continued to do this until she became just a dot in the matchbox-size launch swallowed up in the big blue sea.

Related Characters: Annie John (speaker), Mrs. Annie John, Alexander John

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 345

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Annie and her mother share a final goodbye as Annie sails away. Here, the story ends by emphasizing the changing nature of Annie's relationship with her mother. As Annie reaches in her bag for a red handkerchief that her mother had given her in preparation for this very moment, she—in her own small way—reciprocates her mother's care. While Annie at the beginning of the story may not have wanted to search for her mother in the crowd, Annie at the

end of the story is more mature and able to look at her mother with love. Annie describes herself as waving “wildly,” which further emphasizes that she is passionately participating in this final goodbye. The repetition of the word “wildly” in describing Annie’s mother waving back also suggests that Annie and her mother mirror each other, creating a harmonious image of mother and daughter and suggesting that they have made the first steps toward reconciliation.

While Annie described the sea as “the dark-green water”

and “the deep blue sea” in previous passages, she now describes it in more positive terms: “the big blue sea.” This small change in language represents how Annie’s view of the sea—and leaving Antigua—also shifts and transforms. Instead of emphasizing the darkness or depth of the water, which portrays the water as ominous and even dangerous, Annie’s final description of the sea as “big” emphasizes the multitude of possibilities that she may encounter—both in the water, in England, and anywhere else her future might take her.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

A WALK TO THE JETTY

Seventeen-year-old Annie John wakes up in her family's home in Antigua. In a few hours, she will board a ship to Barbados, which will take her to another ship bound for England, where she will study to become a nurse. Although Annie does not actually want to live in England or be a nurse, she is eager to leave her current life behind and to never again hear the sounds of her mother getting ready in the morning. Annie notes that her room, which she has lived in for 13 years, is full of familiar belongings and memories that once brought her happiness, but she hopes to never return.

Annie reflects on her parents' relationship and vows to never marry. Annie's mother, Mrs. Annie John, is 35 years younger than her husband, Alexander, whom she now takes care of from morning to night. Alexander has grown sickly in his old age yet prefers drinking concoctions of boiled herbs and bark to taking medicine. Annie thinks of how her parents have made everything in their family home—and gave her life, as well. However, she cannot help but view herself as separate from her parents. Annie believes that while she has changed and grown, her parents have remained “just the same,” and she no longer sees or loves them as she once did. Her mother, in particular, strikes Annie as a hypocrite because she swore she could not live without her daughter but arranged Annie's move to England.

Annie John's age and upcoming move from Antigua to England clue the reader in to the importance of this moment in Annie's life. No longer a child but not quite a woman, Annie is on the verge of experiencing significant life changes as she navigates the transition into early adulthood. It is important to note that Annie's cynical view of her current life and her readiness to leave Antigua come from a sense of restriction and confinement. Although Annie's emotions may initially read as teenage angst, her willingness to move across the world and pursue a career she doesn't fully want (as long as she can leave Antigua) points to more complicated inner turmoil.



Mrs. Annie John's dynamic with her husband Alexander represents a traditionally patriarchal relationship in Antiguan society. While Mrs. Annie's dedication to looking after her sick husband conveys her love for him, Annie—and the reader—cannot ignore that Mrs. Annie's life now revolves around what is best for her husband, causing her to deprioritize her own desires. As a teenage girl, Annie looks to her mother as an example of womanhood but finds that her mother's familial values do not align with her own. Altogether, the disconnect and frustration that Annie feels toward her mother makes her feel isolated in her own home—and as though she must move away to experience freedom and explore alternate versions of womanhood.



After a church bell strikes seven, Annie rises to prepare for her big day. She notices that her underclothes emit a strange odor because her mother sent them, along with her jewelry, to an obeah woman who has cast some sort of enchantment to protect her from evil spirits and misfortune. Annie dresses herself in clothes her mother has ironed, and a woman named Miss Cornelia assists Annie with flattening her hair so that her hat will properly fit.

With Antigua not gaining independence until 1981, this story takes place during the period of British colonization. That being said, Mrs. Annie calling upon an obeah woman, or fortune-teller, to cast a protective enchantment on Annie's belongings is a noteworthy reflection of the persistence of native Antiguan culture during colonial times. Although Annie does not fully appreciate her mother's efforts to help prepare her for her move, the reader can see that Mrs. Annie's sending of Annie's belongings to the obeah woman is an extra level of protection that Mrs. Annie wants to provide her daughter. This action reveals both a continued trust in spiritual folk rituals in high-stakes situations like sending a daughter away, and Mrs. Annie's maternal, protective feelings toward Annie. It is also worth noting that Annie's parents are able to afford help from women like Miss Cornelia. While Annie struggles with feeling confined by patriarchal Antiguan society, her family's income, which has made her upcoming move and studies possible, plays an important role in her being able to take her first steps toward freedom.



Annie shares a big "Sunday breakfast" with her parents, complete with "special Sunday bread" from their baker. Mrs. Annie and Alexander speak to Annie excitedly, but Annie cannot help but focus on the horse- and donkey-like noises her parents make as they chew. Mrs. Annie tells her daughter that they won't be surprised if she soon writes home with plans for marriage, and Annie accidentally exclaims, "How absurd!" Although Annie's parents momentarily stop eating, they do not respond to her comment.

Despite Mrs. Annie's and Alexander's attempts to send Annie off on a celebratory note, the family's conversations over breakfast further underscore the dissonance between what Annie wants for her life and the traditional expectations her parents hold. While Mrs. Annie may think she is complimenting her daughter when she expresses her expectation that Annie may soon marry, Annie's accidentally rebellious response emphasizes a lack of clear communication within the family in addition to their difference in values. It is also important to note that since Annie narrates this story, the reader does not have access to her parents' reactions during this moment. Mrs. Annie's and Alexander's silence may, in fact, suggest an attempt to understand their daughter's desires, though they do not verbally express it.



Mrs. Annie's friends stop by to say goodbye to Annie and offer blessings. Although Annie responds politely and with outward joy, her body "ache[s]" at acting with such falseness. As Annie says goodbye to her former friend Gwen, with whom she is no longer close, she finds Gwen embarrassing and like a giggly "schoolgirl" and forces herself not to ask Gwen why she behaves "like such a monkey." Gwen reveals that she expects to soon marry a boy to whom she is "more or less" engaged, and Annie sarcastically wishes her well, though Gwen does not pick up on her tone.

Annie's narration gives the reader access to Annie's bodily experience as she says goodbye to her mother's friends, and it is evident that she feels particularly trapped and uncomfortable while fulfilling gendered expectations of politeness and gratitude. Annie's interactions with her mother's friends and Gwen also demonstrate just how omnipresent traditional gender roles are for women in Antiguan society. Examples of traditional wives and mothers are inescapable, and Annie's description of Gwen as "a monkey" highlights how disconnected—and isolated—Annie feels in this society, which only strengthens her need to escape.



At 10 o'clock, Annie and her parents set off for the jetty. As they walk through town, they pass a seamstress's home, the road to church and school, the doll store, the library, and other places Annie frequented in her youth. She remembers the first time her mother sent her alone to the shop to buy senna and eucalyptus leaves and camphor. She remembers the time her mother ended her friendship with a girl after discovering that she and Annie played together when the girl had mumps. As Annie reminisces on old memories, she begins to feel as if she is "in a dream" and cannot feel her body.

Although Annie describes herself as being in a dream state, her walk through her hometown allows her to awaken to the complexity of her feelings about her home and family. As Annie reflects on her childhood, it becomes clear to the reader that Annie's mother has always supported Annie's independence—she allows Annie to shop alone at a young age—but she also looks after Annie by protecting her from ill friends. Confronting memories that don't fit in with her previous cynical attitude takes a toll on Annie's body, but the awakening that Annie experiences also suggests that she is maturing—and may need to reconsider the critical opinions that have guided her until now.



When Annie and her parents arrive at the jetty, Annie feels overcome by an old fear of "slipping between the boards of the jetty" and drowning in the **water**, where eels live. Realizing that she is about to leave behind everything she knows, Annie finds that she does not know whether to feel happy or sad and feels only trapped. As Annie's parents accompany her in a line of people waiting to board the ship, Annie cannot help but lament that she will never see these familiar sights again or smell the familiar scents of her hometown.

In these moments of fear, Annie experiences an interesting reversal of her attitudes toward her present and future. Annie admits to herself that she finds comfort in the familiarity of home, and, for the first time, she acknowledges that her future may hold dangers—like drowning—that she will have to face alone in a new country. Annie's continued sense of entrapment also suggests that the detrimental effects of strict gender roles are more persistent than they seemed at first. Annie's "freedom," after all, is complex—she is giving up everything she knows to start over in England, but she won't be able to totally escape patriarchy there, either.



The captain of the ship asks Annie and her parents to say their goodbyes quickly. Alexander kisses Annie goodbye and looks as though he is about to say something but ultimately doesn't. Mrs. Annie begins to cry, and Annie finds herself crying, too. When Mrs. Annie hugs her daughter, Annie feels trapped and becomes suddenly suspicious of her mother, but Mrs. Annie reminds her that she will "always be [her] mother and [Antigua] will always be [her] home." They part from one another, and Annie waves a final goodbye after spotting her mother in the crowd of people watching the ship. Upon going to her cabin, she listens to the sound of **waves** against the ship.

As Annie and her parents say their goodbyes, Alexander's restraint suggests that gender roles harm men as well. Burdened by the expectations for men to be tough and unemotional, Alexander is unable to be fully vulnerable with his daughter, even as she is about to leave home. The goodbye between Annie and her mother is more overtly emotional. It is noteworthy that this time, Mrs. Annie is able to verbally communicate her true feelings to her daughter, assuring Annie that their relationship will endure despite strain and distance. Although Annie's narration does not explicitly reveal the emotional impact of her mother's words, the fact that Annie shares an extended goodbye with her mother as the ship sails away suggests that her attitude toward her mother is softening and that, in the future, she might even make peace with their tumultuous relationship.





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